

PROPOSAL · THE ECHELON V0 · WEBSITE &
MEMBER PORTAL

Intentionally simple. Built to grow.

The public website and the private Member Portal, designed on a phone first, launched together in twelve weeks, for one fixed fee. Every question in your wish list is answered here.

PREPARED
FOR

**Joe
Brocato**

IntenseGBD ·
The Echelon

PREPARED BY

Upperhand
Chicago

FIXED
FEE

\$52,000

LAUNCH

**Week
12**



FOUNDING MEMBER · NO. 0001

A V0 as simple as you asked for.

Joe,

Thank you for the wish list. It says what V0 does, what it leaves for later, and what you need from us before you decide. We took it at its word.

This proposal builds the V0 you describe. Members sign in, browse Company Partners, read a profile and press Connect, and the public website launches alongside the portal. The eight questions your document asks are answered in order, just below this letter.

Then it goes a step wider. Where your list leaves a decision open (the Progressive Web App, the native app, the W-9s) we give you our recommendation and the reason for it. And we build V0 so the things you set aside, the Ambassador dashboard, Partner logins and Shared Value, arrive later as new screens on the same foundation, without a rebuild.

One question changes the price: whether W-9s are part of V0. Your document says both, so section 05 sets out the two paths.

John Williamson & Greg McDonald
Upperhand

THE SHORT VERSION

\$52,000

Fixed fee for V0, paid in three parts

12 weeks

From kickoff to launch

2 in 1

Public website and Member Portal, launched together

\$45

A month to run it, on accounts in your name

0

Plugins, templates or retainers

100%

Yours: code, data, design files and accounts

Your eight questions, answered

01

THE BUILD COST

\$52,000, fixed, in three payments tied to milestones.

Investment →

02

RECURRING AND THIRD-PARTY COSTS

About **\$45** a month, itemized. No plugins, no forms to license.

Running costs →

03

TIMELINE AND MILESTONES

Twelve weeks. Design approved in week 5, launch in week 12.

Timeline →

04

MOBILE-FIRST, CONFIRMED

Yes. Every screen is designed on a phone before a desktop.

V0 →

05

A PROGRESSIVE WEB APP?

Yes, in V0. Members add it to their home screen. No app store.

Approach →

06

A NATIVE APP, LATER

\$55,000 to **\$80,000**, preliminary, on the same foundation. No rebuild.

Approach →

07

SECURE W-9S

Two paths. We recommend a specialist service. One question first.

W-9s →

08

SECURITY AND OWNERSHIP

Protected from day one, and yours from day one: code, data, accounts.

Security →

Log in. Browse. Read. Connect.

"Members should be able to log in, browse Company Partners by ecosystem/category, view Company Partner profiles, and initiate contact with a Company Partner."

Your bottom line for the portal, September 21

WHAT IS WORKING WHEN

- 01 A visitor can request Founding Membership on a phone in under a minute.
- 02 A Member gets from sign-in to a sent introduction in three taps.
- 03 Every Connect is on record: the Member, the Company Partner, the date and the time.
- 04 Every Member carries their source, and their Ambassador where there is one, from the day they ask to join.
- 05 Your team makes routine changes without calling us.
- 06 Every page loads in under 2 seconds on a phone.
- 07 Nobody mistakes it for a template.

Everything on your list. **Nothing that isn't.**

THE PUBLIC WEBSITE

HOME | THE ECHELON | EXPLORE | OUR STANDARDS | MEMBERSHIP |
SIGN IN

Home	The proposition in one scroll: trusted access, Member Benefits, the Member Advantage, the two ecosystems, and the invitation to request Founding Membership.
The Echelon	What it is, why it exists, how it works, and who Members, Company Partners and Ambassadors are.
Explore	The two ecosystems and their categories. Partner names stay inside the portal.
Our Standards	The six Standards, how Company Partners are selected and reviewed, what is expected of them, and the disclaimer.
Membership	Who it is for, the benefits, Founding Membership, and a short request form.

THE MEMBER PORTAL

PRIVATE • MEMBERS ONLY • INSTALLS TO THE HOME SCREEN

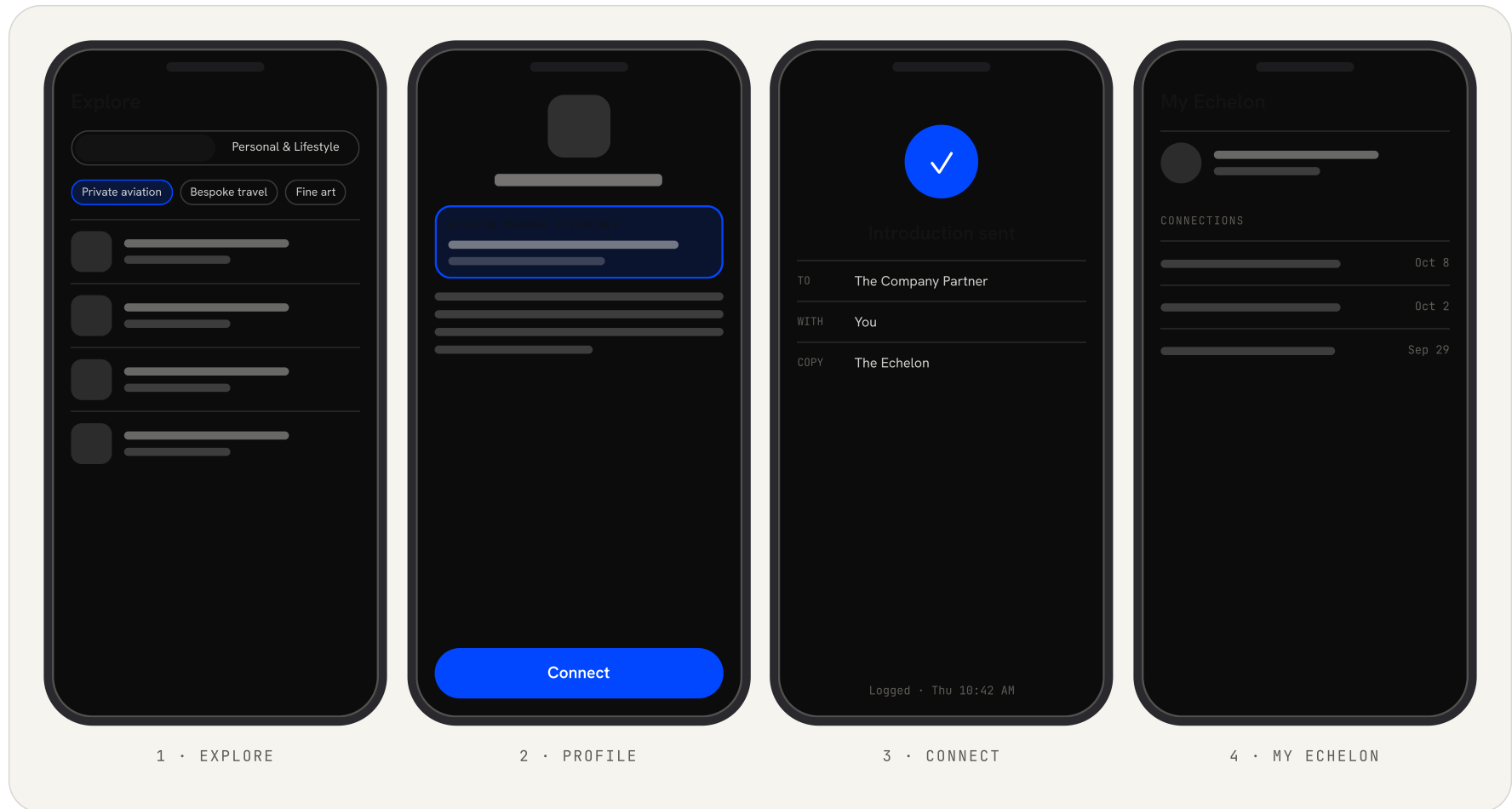
Home	An elegant welcome and three ways in: Explore, recent Partners, My Echelon.
Explore	Company Partners by ecosystem and category.
Profiles	One template your team fills in admin: overview, services, differentiators, reach, contact, video, and the Echelon Member Advantage set apart at the top.
Connect	One button. It logs the request and sends the introduction email. More below.
My Echelon	The Member's details and every Partner they have asked to meet.

Sign In

Straight into the portal. Footer: About, Contact, Privacy, Terms, Company Partner Disclaimer.

Admin

Members, Partners, profiles, categories, Advantages, the membership queue, the connection report. Constant Contact stays in sync.



Wireframes, not the design. The look comes out of discovery and your brand standards.

When a Member presses Connect

01

The press is logged

Before any email goes out: the Member, the Company Partner, the date and the time.

02

One introduction goes out

From The Echelon, to the Partner, with the Member on the thread and IntenseGBD copied. Exactly the email you described.

03

They carry on by email

You are on the first message, so the introduction is in your records as well as the portal's.

04

It shows up twice

In the Member's My Echelon, and in your connection report, where it can be filtered and exported.

LEFT OUT OF V0, ON PURPOSE

~~Transaction and revenue tracking~~

Later, as Shared Value

~~An Ambassador portal or login~~

Later. The data is ready from day one

~~Partners editing their own profiles~~

Later, as Partner logins

~~Marketing automation~~

Constant Contact covers V0

~~Member social profiles and community~~

Not planned

~~Hosting our own video~~

YouTube embeds instead

Where you asked for advice, **our advice.**

Your list decides most of V0. These are the calls it leaves open, and what we would do with each.

01 Build it custom, not on WordPress.

You said it cannot look off-the-shelf, and a site built from plugins usually does. We build on Next.js, Postgres and Vercel. The tools are standard and well documented, so another developer could take it over, and with no plugins there is nothing to patch every month.

IN V0

03 Keep Connect on email, and log it at the button.

Your instinct is right: people answer email. The portal records the press before the email is sent, so the log is complete even when the conversation moves to email. Your team can mark each introduction as made, in conversation or closed. That records no dollar amounts, so V0 still tracks no revenue.

IN V0

02 Make the portal a Progressive Web App now.

Members add it to their home screen from the browser. It opens full screen with your icon and stays signed in. It costs nothing extra in V0, and it tells you how Members actually use a phone before you pay for an app.

IN V0

04 Give every Ambassador a personal link.

Anyone who requests membership through an Ambassador's link arrives with the Ambassador already recorded. For everyone else, the form asks how they heard of The Echelon. Your team confirms the answer at approval, and any later change is logged.

IN V0

05 Store Ambassadors and Partners as real records now.

Not names typed into a field. That way the Ambassador dashboard and Partner logins are new screens on existing data, not a migration. This is how V0 meets your “without substantial rework”.

IN V0

07 Launch Explore with no empty shelves.

An empty category reads as a missing one. In the portal, a category appears once it has a live Partner. The public Explore page can still show every category you plan to fill.

YOUR CALL

06 Shape the profile around your questionnaire.

Partners already answer your Company Partner Profile questionnaire. We build the profile template field for field from it, so what they send you drops straight into admin.

IN V0

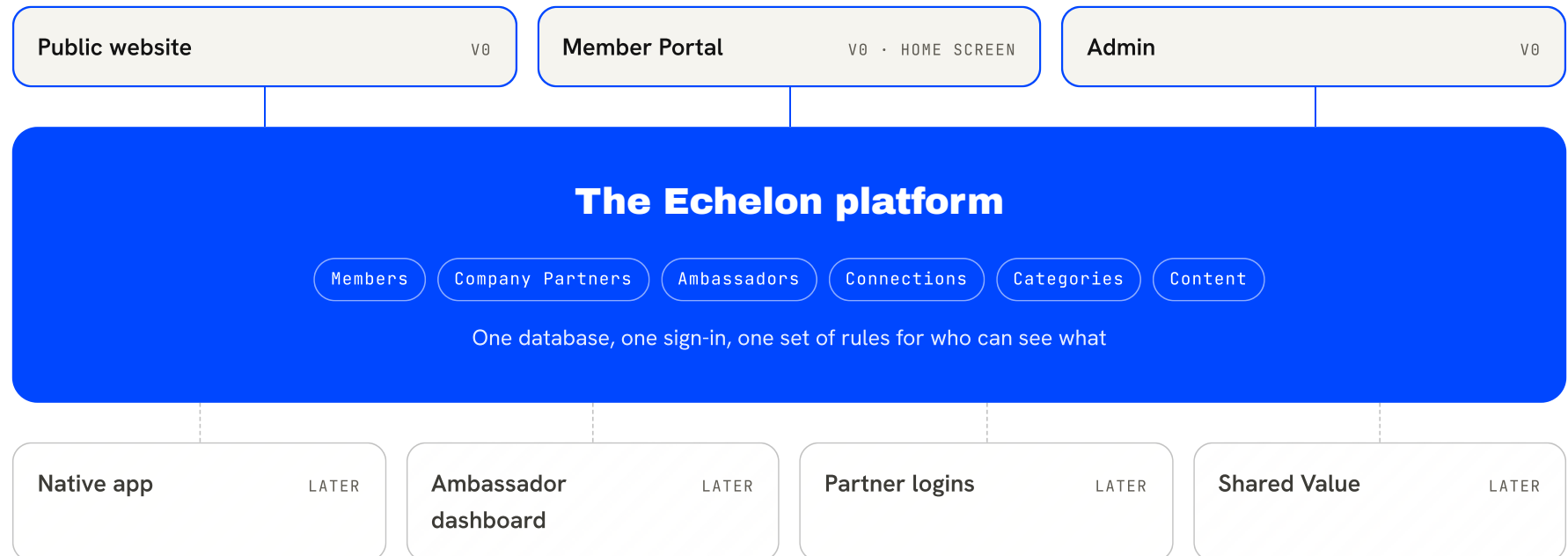
08 The fine print stays on your side of the table.

Terms, Privacy and the Company Partner Disclaimer are legal documents, so the words come from you. We set them into the site and ask Members to accept them at enrollment, with the time recorded.

YOUR CALL

One foundation, every front door

Everything sits on one platform. What you add later, you add at the edges.



The home screen now, an app when it earns it

Launch the portal as a Progressive Web App. Watch how Members use it for three to six months. If you then want a store listing, or you are adding features a browser can't handle, build the native app on the same foundation. The database, sign-in, admin and every rule carry over. Only the screens are new.

NATIVE IOS AND ANDROID APP • PRELIMINARY

\$55,000 to \$80,000

12 to 16 weeks, both platforms from one codebase. Plus Apple's developer program at \$99 a year and Google Play's \$25 one-time fee. We would quote it properly once V0 is in use.

WEB APP, V0 NATIVE APP

WHAT EACH ONE GETS YOU

Icon on the home screen	Yes	Yes
Opens full screen, stays signed in	Yes	Yes
iPhone and Android	Yes	Yes
Updates reach everyone	Instantly	After store review
Listed in the App Store and Google Play	No	Yes
Push notifications	Once installed	Yes
Cost	Included	\$55,000 to \$80,000

One question before we build.

"We do not intend to store W-9s, Social Security numbers or other sensitive tax information in the V0 portal."

Your document, under Security and Privacy

"We expect to collect completed Forms W-9 from Members and Echelon Ambassadors and would prefer ... that they be securely submitted through the Platform."

Your document, under Secure W-9 Collection and Storage

Which one holds for V0? The answer changes what we build on day one, so we have priced both.

PATH A · OUR RECOMMENDATION

A specialist service holds the forms.

Members and Ambassadors complete their W-9 with a tax-form service built for exactly this. The portal stores only the status and a reference, never the form.

- ✓ Encryption, access control and audits are the service's specialty and its liability
- ✓ Services like these usually also check tax ID numbers and file the 1099s
- ✓ Admin shows each record as requested, received or verified

\$1,500

to connect it, plus the service's own fees

PATH B

We build secure storage into the platform.

The forms live with us, in storage kept apart from everything else, and only designated IntenseGBD administrators can open them.

- ✓ Encrypted in transit and at rest, in segregated storage
- ✓ Two-factor sign-in, and every view and download written to an audit log
- ✓ Backups, plus a retention and deletion schedule you set

\$8,000

added to V0, and the security responsibility that comes with it

Either way: no W-9 is ever an ordinary upload, and the admin record shows its status without exposing a single number from the form.

Protected from day one. Yours from day one.

HOW V0 IS PROTECTED

- ✓ Encrypted in transit on every page, and encrypted at rest in the database
- ✓ Members see only their own record and their own history, enforced by the database, not just the screen
- ✓ Administrators sign in with two-factor authentication
- ✓ Every admin change is logged: who, what and when
- ✓ Daily backups kept for seven days, plus a monthly export to storage you control
- ✓ Rate limits and spam protection on sign-in and every form
- ✓ No Social Security numbers or tax information stored in V0, unless you choose Path B

WHAT YOU OWN

- ✓ The website, the portal, the database and every line of custom code
- ✓ The design files, the content, and all Member and Company Partner data
- ✓ Every account, opened in IntenseGBD's name from the first week. We work as invited collaborators
- ✓ A one-click export of Members, Partners and connections from admin
- ✓ A written handover, so another host or developer can take it over

ACCOUNTS IN YOUR NAME

Domain

Vercel

Supabase

Resend

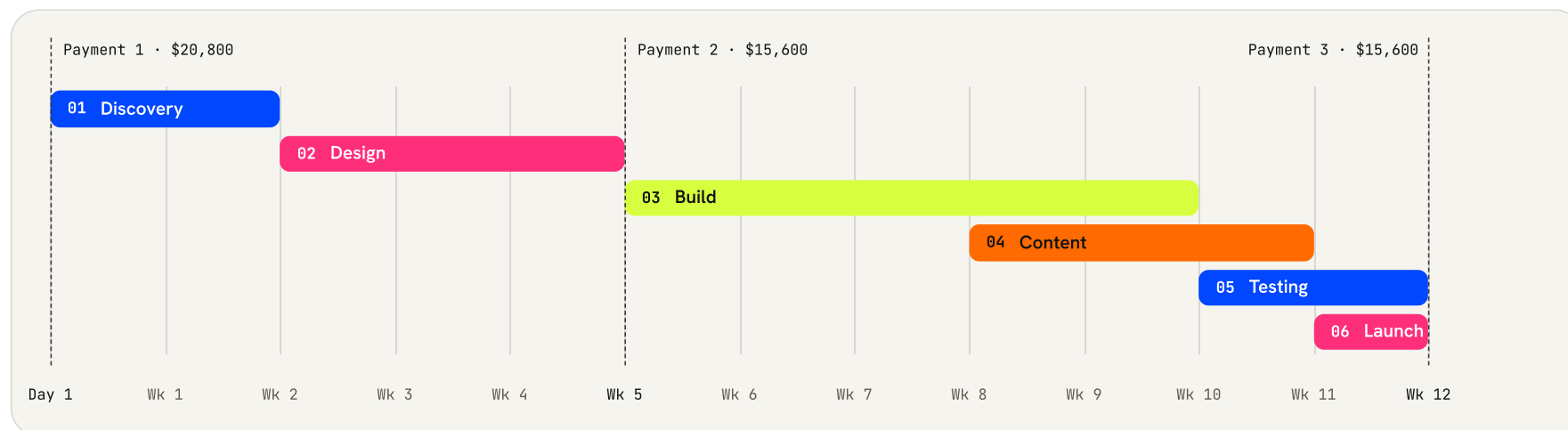
Constant Contact

GitHub

Figma

Twelve weeks, six milestones.

Your milestones, in your words: design approval, development, testing, content population, user acceptance testing and launch. Two of them trigger a payment.



01 Discovery & planning

Day 1 to week 2

A working session on the Member journey, a look at your questionnaire, and the decisions that shape the build: roles, the profile template, the Connect email.

YOU GET

the sitemap, the data model and a signed-off plan

WE NEED

two hours with you, your brand standards and the questionnaire

02 Design

Weeks 2 to 5

Your brand carried into a digital system, then every page and screen, phone first. A clickable prototype of the portal and two rounds of revisions.

YOU GET

the approved design, milestone 1

WE NEED

one decision-maker for the reviews

03 Development

Weeks 5 to 10

The website, the portal, admin, Connect, Constant Contact and security, built in that order. You get a private preview link on the first day of the phase, and it changes every week.

YOU GET

a working preview to click through each week

WE NEED

the Constant Contact account and the final text of the legal pages

04 Content population

Weeks 8 to 11

Your team enters the first Company Partners in admin, with us beside you for the first few. Page copy goes in, videos get embedded.

YOU GET

admin training while it matters

WE NEED

the launch Partners' profile information and logos

05 Testing & user acceptance

Weeks 10 to 12

We test on iPhone, Android and desktop. Then your team, and a few Founding Members if you want, use it for real and send us everything they find.

YOU GET

a fix list, closed before launch

WE NEED

your sign-off that it is ready

06 Launch

Week 12

The site replaces "Launching Soon" at theechelonsignature.com and the portal opens to approved Members. Thirty days of fixes follow.

YOU GET

V0, live, milestone 2

WE NEED

your first invitations ready to send

One fixed fee for V0.

\$52,000

Fixed, for everything in sections 03 and 06. If the scope holds, the price holds. If you add something, we price it in writing before we start it.

THREE PAYMENTS

40% At signing
Day 1 **\$20,800**

30% Milestone 1: design approved
Week 5 **\$15,600**

30% Milestone 2: launch
Week 12 **\$15,600**

LINE	ITEM	FIXED
01	Discovery & planning - A working session with you on the Member journey, from the request form to the first Connect - The Company Partner profile template, shaped around the questionnaire Partners already fill in - Sitemap, data model, roles and the Connect email, signed off before design starts	\$4,000
02	Brand extension & design - Your logo and brand standards carried into a digital system: type, color, spacing, components - Every public page and portal screen, designed on a phone first, then on a desktop - A clickable prototype of the portal and two rounds of revisions - Vector versions of the logo, redrawn if they do not exist yet	\$12,000
03	Public website - Home, The Echelon, Explore, Our Standards, Membership and Sign In, plus the footer pages - The Request Founding Membership form, with the source and Ambassador captured on the way in - Search basics, social previews, video embeds, and the Terms, Privacy and Company Partner Disclaimer pages	\$7,000
04	Member Portal - Sign in, the Member home, Explore by ecosystem and category, and Company Partner profiles - A prominent Echelon Member Advantage on every profile - Connect: the email introduction, logged at the button with the Member, the Partner, the date and the time - My Echelon, with account details and connection history - Installs to the home screen on iPhone and Android, as a Progressive Web App	\$14,000
05	Administration - Add, edit and remove Members, Company Partners, profiles, categories, Member Advantages and page content - The membership queue: approve a request, send the enrollment link, and track it to the first sign-in - The connection report, filterable and exportable, and the source and Ambassador on every Member record	\$6,000
06	Integrations & security - Constant Contact: approved Members added to your list automatically - Email for Connect introductions, sign-in links and approvals, sent from your domain - Two-factor sign-in for administrators, an audit log of admin changes, daily backups, rate limits on every form	\$4,000
07	Content, testing & launch - Loading the first Company Partner profiles with you - Testing on iPhone, Android and desktop, then user acceptance testing with your team - Launch, an hour of admin training, a written guide, and thirty days of fixes after launch	\$5,000
Total, fixed fee		\$52,000

What it costs to run

Everything outside our fee, as you asked: hosting, plugins, forms, email, security, backups, maintenance and Constant Contact. Checked against each vendor's published prices on September 25.

WHAT	NOTE	MONTHLY
Hosting and security certificates Vercel Pro	Includes SSL, a global network and attack protection	\$20
Database, sign-in, file storage and daily backups Supabase Pro	Backups kept for 7 days	\$25
Connect introductions and sign-in email Resend	Free to 3,000 emails a month, then \$20	\$0
Forms and plugins Built in	Nothing to license	\$0
Member email Constant Contact	Your existing plan. Connecting it adds nothing	Yours today
Domain theechelonsignature.com	You already own it; the renewal stays yours	Yours today
At launch		\$45

AT LAUNCH

\$45 a month

ONLY IF YOU NEED IT

More than 3,000 emails a month +\$20 a month

Restore to any minute, not just the last daily backup +\$100 a month

App store accounts, \$99 a year + \$25 once once there is an app

MAINTENANCE

No retainer. After the thirty days of fixes, you buy hours when you need them.

Priced now, so nothing later is a surprise

W-9s, through a specialist service **RECOMMENDED**

Our recommendation. We connect the service and show each Member's W-9 status in admin. The service's own fees are separate.

\$1,500

one time

W-9s, stored in the platform

Encrypted, segregated storage with administrator-only access, two-factor sign-in, an audit log and a retention schedule.

\$8,000

one time

Block of hours

Ten hours for changes, new pages and updates after the thirty days of fixes. Prepaid, used as needed, no retainer.

\$1,500

per 10-hour block

V1 features

The Ambassador dashboard, Partner logins, Shared Value tracking. Scoped and quoted one at a time, when you are ready.

Quoted

one at a time

Native iOS and Android app

A preliminary range, on the same foundation as V0. We would quote it properly after a few months of real use.

\$55,000 to \$80,000

preliminary

About Upperhand

Upperhand is a studio in Chicago, led by John Williamson and Greg McDonald. We've spent decades starting, running and selling companies, and building the brands and products inside them.

Both of us work on The Echelon with you from kickoff to launch, supported internally by our dedicated team. We've hired agencies ourselves, which is why this proposal has a fixed fee, an end date, and accounts in your name.

What happens next

01

Walk through it

A call with both of us to go through the scope and the recommendations, and answer your questions.

02

Settle the W-9s

Path A, Path B, or not in V0. Whichever it is, the final number follows the same day.

03

Sign

A short services agreement by e-signature, with this scope attached as written.

04

Kick off

Within five business days of the first payment. Twelve weeks later, V0 is live.

John Williamson

john@getupperhand.io

Greg McDonald

greg@getupperhand.io



Prepared for Joe Brocato, IntenseGBD, LLC · The Echelon, September 25, 2026. Confidential. Running costs are each vendor's published price on September 25, 2026, and may change. The Echelon name and logo belong to IntenseGBD, LLC.

© 2026 Upperhand LLC · hello@getupperhand.io